

Urbanisation in India began to accelerate after independence, due to the country's adoption of a mixed economy, which gave rise to the development of the private sector. The population residing in urban areas in India, according to the 1901 census, was 11.4%, increasing to 28.53% by the 2001 census, and stood at 35.69% in 2025 according to the World Bank. According to a survey by the United Nations, in 2030 40.76% of country's population is expected to reside in urban areas. As per the World Bank, India, along with China, Indonesia, Nigeria, and the United States, will lead the world's urban population surge by 2050.

Mumbai saw large-scale rural-urban migration in the 20th century. In 2018, Mumbai accommodated 22.1 million people, and was the second-largest metropolis by population in India. Delhi has 28 million inhabitants and witnessed the fastest rate of urbanisation in the world, with a 4.1% rise in population as per the 2011 census of India.

History

Post-independence, India faced high rates of poverty, unemployment, and a stagnant economy. Post-independence India focused on the domain of science and technology. The mixed economy system was adopted, resulting in the growth of the Public sector in India crippling down the development of Indian economy leading to what is popularly known as Hindu rate of growth. The South Asian region though predominantly rural (accounting for 69.9% rural population as of 2010), has recorded much higher annual growth of urban population. India, the leading country in South Asia has shown an unprecedented increase in the urban population in the last few decades and its urban population has increased about 14 fold from 1901 to 2011. This growth is mainly uneven but not skewed and not concentrated to a single city of the country. India shares most characteristic features of urbanisation in the developing countries where the rate of urbanisation is faster than the developed countries. For instance, in 1971 there were only about 150 cities whose population was more than one lakh, now this figure has reached to 500. The urban population of India has increased from

25.85 million in 1901 to 377.11 million in 2011.

Modern India

Since 1941, India has witnessed the rapid growth of its four largest metropolitan cities: Kolkata, Delhi, Mumbai, and Chennai. The nation's economy has undergone Industrial Revolution, thus increasing the standard of living of people living in urban areas. The growth of the public sector resulted in development of public transport, roads, water supply, electricity, and other infrastructure of urban areas.

As the percentage contribution of the secondary sector to India's GDP has increased, the percentage contribution from the agricultural sector has declined. It is estimated that the agricultural sector provides employment to 50% of the country's workforce, but accounts for only 18% of the GDP. Many farmers in different states of India are leaving farming, primarily because of high input cost and low income from agriculture. Also, the prolonged use of fertilizers, chemicals, and hybrid seeds has led to a decline in land fertility. Struggling to make a living, many farmers have committed suicide.

Maharashtra was the most urbanized major state in India till 1991, stood behind Tamil Nadu in 2001 and third after it in 2011, with Kerala being second, with the urban-total state population ratio. However, Maharashtra's urban population of 41 million, far exceeds that of Tamil Nadu which is at 27 million, as per the 2001 census. The spatial distribution of large cities in India is uneven as out of 100 most populous cities in the country more than 50 are confined to only 5 states namely, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Andhra Pradesh. The World Bank estimated in 2011 that two thirds of India's GDP was generated in cities.

In 2014, World Bank projected that by 2030, India's top five cities would have economies comparable to middle income countries in 2014.

The rapid expansion of Indian cities has frequently led to the encroachment of natural

ecosystems. Wetlands in Indian cities, such as lakes, floodplains, and marshes, have faced significant degradation due to unplanned construction and infrastructure development. While these water bodies provide essential services like flood mitigation and groundwater recharge, they are often missing from formal urban planning discourse.

Causes of urbanisation in India

The main causes of urbanisation in India are:

Expansion in government services, as a result of the Second World War

Migration of people during the partition of India

Industrial development in urban areas

India's eleventh Five-Year Plan, which targeted urbanisation as a means to accelerate economic development

Economic opportunities, including employment

Better opportunities for education

Infrastructure facilities in urban areas

Growth of the private sector after 1990

Land fragmentation: some villages have been erased due to construction of roads, highways, dams, and other infrastructure

Non-profitability of farming

Urban unemployment

The National Sample Survey Organisation reported the following urban unemployment rates for the period July 2011–June 2012:

References

Bibliography

Ballhatchet, Kenneth; Harrison, John (1980). The City in South Asia: Pre-Modern and Modern. Curzon Press. ISBN 9780391011298.

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